DAILY READING • 样张

The Third Bottle

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短文

The night shift at the bottling plant began at eleven, and Mara spotted the first fault before midnight. A steel rod on the filler arm had worked loose again, and the rubber strap beside it was frayed along one edge. She crawled under the conveyor with a torch and counted the screws that held the steel guard in place. One of the four screws that should have anchored the guard was missing altogether. She tightened the remaining three with a short wrench, then walked the whole line slowly to inspect every seal. A lamp on a tall pole outside cast a yellow band across the wet floor. Beyond the fence, the empty residence blocks of the company town stood dark against the ridge.

At two she ran the standard plate test, and the reading made her sit down on the stool. The water in the third bottle had begun to undergo a change that no one had logged. Bacteria of a single colony type had multiplied far past the limit printed in the lab manual. The manual named a specific threshold for this line, and the concentration in the third bottle sat nine times above it. The artificial sweetener used on the diet run was not the origin of the growth, she was almost sure. The real characteristic of the bloom was its speed, and the most noticeable sign was a faint smell of wet cardboard. The seals themselves were of an inferior grade, ordered in June to save money.

Ruiz, the executive who governed the floor, walked in at three with his coat still on. He ran the plant like a dictator and expected the night crew to agree before he spoke. Above his desk hung a banner from 1998, the year the plant was crowned the best bottler in the province. He treated that banner as others treat a religion, and mentioned it to every visitor. He offered her a promotion to the day lab if she would claim the sample had been contaminated. There was an accord between the plant and the city, he said, and it could be read in two ways. She wanted absolute proof before she signed anything, and he did not have it.

The revelation came from a folder he left open, and it changed the shape of the night. Inside were the papers of an investigation closed in September without a single fine. A concerning

pattern ran through them: the same seal supplier, the same rushed orders, the same silence. She reckoned that at least six batches had shipped with counts above the legal limit. The notion that a small plant could hide such a record puzzled her more than the numbers did. Her first impression of Ruiz had been of a tired man, and it now looked like a mistake. He was more influential in the valley than any individual on the city water board. She copied the folder, and the act of copying relieved her more than she expected.

By five she had called the city inspector, and by seven the line was sealed. The company did not go bankrupt, though reporters chased the story for a fortnight. The board met on Friday, and the welfare of two hundred workers was weighed accordingly. One destructive habit had done more harm than any single bad machine. The plant evolved slowly after that, with new seals, a second tester and an honest log. She polished the report until every date could be checked by a stranger. An accidental detail stayed with her: a moth resting on the lamp pole at dawn. The original sample still sat in the fridge, labelled in her own handwriting. The sky over the ridge turned a gorgeous orange as she drove home.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

The **night shift** at the bottling plant began at eleven, and Mara spotted the first fault before midnight. A steel rod on the filler arm had **worked loose** again, and the rubber strap beside it was frayed along one edge. She crawled under the conveyor with a torch and counted the screws that held the steel guard **in place**. One of the four screws that should have anchored the guard was missing altogether. She tightened the remaining three with a short wrench, then walked the whole line slowly to inspect every seal. A lamp on a tall pole outside cast a yellow band across the wet floor. Beyond the fence, the empty residence blocks of the company town stood dark against the ridge.

> **night shift** 夜班 固定说法，不加冠词说 on the night shift；指整段班次，不指某个人
> **worked loose** （螺丝、接头）受震后松脱 work 在这里是不及物动词，后接形容词 loose / free 表结果；不能换成 loosened，loosened 强调人为拧松
> **in place** 在应在的位置上，安装到位 常与 hold / keep / stay 连用；hold sth in place 是把某物固定住不让它移动

At two she ran the standard plate test, and the reading made her sit down on the stool. The water in the third bottle had begun to undergo a change that no one had logged. Bacteria of a single colony type had multiplied **far past the limit** printed in the lab manual. The manual named a specific threshold for this line, and the concentration in the third bottle sat nine times above it. The artificial sweetener used on the diet run was not **the origin of** the growth, she was almost sure. The real characteristic of the bloom was its speed, and the most noticeable sign was **a faint smell of** wet cardboard. The seals themselves were of an inferior grade, ordered in June to save money.

> **far past the limit** 远远超过限值 past 在此表超出某一界线，比 beyond the limit 更口语；修饰语用 far / well 前置加强
> **the origin of** ……的来源、根源 origin 与介词 of 搭配指来源；指人的出身用 origins（复数），如 humble origins
> **a faint smell of** 一股淡淡的……气味 smell of 后接气味来源；程度词用 faint / slight，反义用 strong / pungent

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> **promotion to** 晋升到（某一职位） 介词固定用 to，不用 into；动词搭配是 get / earn / offer a promotion
> **an accord between** （两方之间的）协议 accord 作名词较正式，常见于外交与劳资语境；between 后接双方，reach an accord 表示达成协议
> **absolute proof** 确凿的证据 absolute 修饰不可分级的抽象名词，不用 very absolute；同义搭配是 conclusive proof

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> **above the legal limit** 超过法定限值 above 表数值高于标准，反义 below；limit 前惯用 legal / safety / speed 等定语
>
> **The notion that** ……这一观念、想法 notion 后接 that 引导的同位语从句说明内容；比 idea 更强调未必成立的主观看法
>
> **first impression of** 对……的第一印象 impression 与介词 of 搭配指对象，与 on 搭配指给某人留下的印象，如 make an impression on sb

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> **go bankrupt** 破产 go 后接形容词表状态转变，不加冠词；及物说法是 bankrupt a company，名词是 bankruptcy
> **chased the story** 追这条新闻、盯住这条线索 新闻业固定说法，chase a story 指记者持续追查；chase 后也可接 sb for sth 表追着某人要东西
> **in her own handwriting** 她自己的笔迹 handwriting 是不可数名词，不说 a handwriting；in sb's handwriting 表“是某人的字迹”

译文

装瓶厂的夜班十一点开始，而玛拉在午夜前就发现了第一处故障。灌装臂上的一根钢杆又松了，旁边那条橡胶带有一侧边缘已经磨散。她打着电筒爬到输送带下面，数了数固定钢护罩的螺丝。四颗螺丝里该有一颗锚住护罩的那颗，却整个不见了。她用一把短扳手把剩下的三颗拧紧，然后慢慢走完整条生产线，逐个检查密封圈。外面一根高杆上的灯把一道黄光投在湿漉漉的地面上。围栏之外，公司家属区那些空着的住宅在岭脊前黑成一片。

凌晨两点，她做了例行的平板培养检验，读数让她一屁股坐在凳子上。第三瓶里的水已经开始发生一种没人记进日志的变化。单一菌落类型的细菌繁殖量早已远远超过实验室手册印着的限值。手册给这条线规定了明确的阈值，而第三瓶的数值高出九倍。减肥线用的人造甜味剂不是这股增长的根源，她几乎可以肯定。这团菌群真正的特征是它的速度，最显而易见的迹象是一股淡淡的湿纸板味。密封圈本身是次一等的货色，六月为省钱订的。

鲁伊斯是管着车间的主管，三点钟进来时大衣都没脱。他把厂子当独裁者的地盘来管，还指望夜班的人在他开口之前就点头。他办公桌上方挂着一面 1998 年的横幅，那一年厂子被评为全省最好的装瓶厂。他把那面横幅当别人信教一样对待，每来一个访客都要提一遍。他说只要她声称样品是被污染的，就给她升到白班实验室。厂里和市里之间有份协议，他说，那份协议可以有两种读法。她要的是签字之前的确凿证据，而他没有。

真相来自他摊在桌上没合上的一个文件夹，它改变了这个夜晚的形状。里面是一桩调查的卷宗，那桩调查在九月就结了，一分钱罚款都没有。一条令人不安的规律贯穿其中：同一家密封圈供应商，同样赶工的订单，同样的沉默。她估计至少六个批次已经带着超过法定限值的数值出了厂。一家小厂竟能藏住这样一份记录，这件事比那些数字更让她困惑。她对鲁伊斯的第一印象原是个疲惫的人，而那个印象现在看起来像个错误。他在这一带的影响力，比市水务委员会里任何一个个人都大。她把文件夹复印了一份，复印这个动作给她的宽慰超出她的预期。

五点前她给市里的检查员打了电话，七点整条线被封了。公司并没有破产，尽管本地报纸连追了两个星期说它要破产。董事会周五开会，两百名工人的福利也相应地摆上了天平。一个破坏性的习惯造成的损害，比任何一台坏机器都大。此后厂子慢慢变了过来：新密封圈，第二台检测仪，一本诚实的日志。她把报告润色到每一个日期都能让陌生人核实。有个偶然的细节留在了她心里：天亮时一只蛾子停在灯杆上。那份最初的样品还在冰箱里，标签是她自己的笔迹。她开车回家时，山脊上的天空翻成一片极漂亮的橙色。